

We should see it in that essential light. There is a need for Pakistan to dismantle the infrastructure of terrorism on its territory or the ones under its control. We will naturally centre our discussions on these concerns," she told INDIA TODAY.

While the prime minister is looking at the big picture and may have the right intentions, the problem is dealing with a recalcitrant neighbour which views terror as a tool to stop India's emergence as a global player. That leads to a fundamental difference of approach: on one side, a democratic country determined to promote peace, on the other, a fragile nation with a charade of a civilian government but the Army calling the shots. The fundamental flaw is the asymmetry between the two countries in their respective approaches to these negotiations.

Terrorists cannot be allowed to set the agenda, and the decision to talk or not to talk must not be guided by these acts. But India needs a focused approach at these talks to flag its concerns on terrorism which remains the biggest impediment to peace between the two south Asian neighbours. Pakistan must be assessed on its deeds and not on its rhetoric of ending terrorism. India also needs to send out a signal that it will not be business as usual without getting its concerns addressed. Now that the two foreign secretaries are set to meet next week with terror as the focus, there are obvious areas that the talks should be focusing on, apart from issues like extradition of fugitives, moving forward on creative solutions on Kashmir and resolving potential conflict triggers. The INDIA TODAY Board of Experts on Security and Terror (BEST) have been discussing these issues in past meetings and we asked them to chalk out the direction the talks should take, along with our own analysis on issues that need to be addressed in the light of the return of terror after a 14-month reprieve.

hetic of ending terrorism.

The BEST Verdict



INDIA TODAY's Board of Experts on Security and Terror outline the strategies for the Indo-Pak talks that are likely to help India address its concerns on cross-border terror

1. Action Against the Perpetrators of 26/11

The 26/11 Mumbai terror attacks were a game changer in cross-border terrorism as for the first time many foreign nationals were killed in an attack that led to intense global pressure on Pakistan. It forced Islamabad to act. Ajmal Kasab, the lone surviving attacker, was arrested and he spilled the beans on the Pakistan connection. Pakistan conceded that the 26/11 attacks were planned in its territory and the Pakistan-based terror group Lashkar-e-Toiba (LeT) was involved.

What needs to be done: While seven of the accused, including Zakir-ur-Rahman Lakhvi and Zafar Shah of LeT have been arrested, key mastermind Hafiz Mohammed Saeed, chargesheeted by India, has not been arrested. Pakistan has done a series of flip-flops and the trial has been tardy and chances are only the small fish may get punished. India must insist that Pakistan should book the perpetrators, including Saeed, in a fast track court so that the guilty of 26/11 can be punished. If it manages to do so, it will be an important indicator that Pakistan is serious about addressing India's concern on Pakistan-sponsored terrorism.

2. Extradition of Most Wanted Fugitives

For more than a decade, India has been seeking extradition of 37 fugitives, including Dawood Ibrahim, the IC-814 hijackers, militant leaders like Syed Salahuddin, Saeed, besides some Sikh terrorists. The details of their addresses and presence, including newspaper clippings, were given to Pakistan during a joint terror mechanism meeting in 2008 but

Islamabad continued to deny the existence and some of them even shifted their bases. Pakistan, on its part, handed over a parallel list to India, seeking some of its fugitives.

What needs to be done: If Pakistan is sincere, it should begin by handing over at least some of the fugitives on India's list as there are Interpol red corner notices pending against them. India, in turn, can also reciprocate by handing over some fugitives as has been done in case of Bangladesh.

3. Action Against Terror Infrastructure

Despite promises to clamp down on terrorism by Pakistan, including an assurance by its former president Pervez Musharraf that its territory will not be allowed for terror attacks, Islamabad continues to provide safe haven to terror groups. Recent intelligence estimates suggest that over three dozen terror camps continue to function in Pakistan.

What needs to be done: India must seek verifiable action against terror infrastructure. There is need for Pakistan to dismantle the infrastructure of terrorism on its territory or the ones under its control. India should centre the discussions on these concerns. The important point is to be able to express India's stand clearly, safeguarding its interests.

4. Dialogue Between Intelligence Chiefs

Whenever there is a terror attack, a blame game ensues between the two external intelligence agencies—Pakistan's Inter Services Intelligence (ISI) and India's Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW). After the 26/11 terror attacks in Mumbai, Pakistan